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Grieving the loss of a pet: A qualitative systematic review

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ABSTRACT

Animal owners who experience the death of a beloved family pet or companion animal may experience feelings of grief and loss that are synonymous with the death of a human. This systematic review synthesized 19 qualitative papers from 17 studies that explored the psychosocial impact of bereavement and grieving the loss of a pet. The analysis revealed five themes: Their Relationship; Their Grief; Their Guilt; Their Supports; and Their Future. By looking beyond grief, health professionals can respond to bereaved pet owners the same way they would for other forms of human bereavement and provide the necessary support to transition bereavement.

Social values naturally attribute grief to the loss of human life, yet the loss of a pet can also be met with a reaction of grief by owners or close humans. Despite the experience of grief following the loss of a pet, this form of bereavement is less readily sanctioned and thus creates an artificial differentiation between grief for those we love—human and pet. The lesser acknowledgment of bereavement of pets has been described as one form of disenfranchised grief (Doka, 1999; Thompson & Cox, 2017).

The loss of a pet presents some challenges and realities not normally associated with human death that can further compound how grief is experienced and how prolonged a period of bereavement might be. Most pet owners are aware at the time of bringing the pet into their lives that they will most likely outlive the pet, given the shorter life spans of most domestic animals, and therefore grief can be almost anticipated from the outset of the relationship, known as anticipatory grief (Hamilton, 2016). This shorter life span and anticipatory grief can also lead to the experience of multiple bereavements associated with subsequent pets. This repeated experience of bereavement, coupled with a sense of disenfranchised grief, can have mental health impacts for those seeking to recover from the experience of loss (Westgarth et al., 2013). Furthermore, pet loss can be differentiated from human loss through the unique experience of

euthanasia with the owner taking a direct role in determining the timing and manner of their pet's death, and impacted by factors not normally associated with a human death, such as the cost of treatment influencing the decision to euthanize (Hewson, 2014).

This analysis of pet bereavement, therefore, presents two unique challenges faced by pet owners: factors relating to the death of a pet that are not normally experienced with a human death, and a society that does not seemingly value and support grief for pets in the same way it does for humans. This can create an experience of pet bereavement that is impacted by both these challenges. A growing body of research has emerged to examine these experiences and their multi-dimensional findings. As such, synthesis of the results of this broad array of research is warranted. Previous systematic analyses have examined the lived experience of companion animal loss but have not focused exclusively on loss through death (Kemp et al., 2016). Grief varies with the nature of the loss, creating unique experiences for each. Examining one type of loss, such as death, allows extension of the knowledge base and the ability to compare the nature of the death-related loss to other forms of loss in subsequent research. Additionally, previous systematic reviews have excluded the incorporation of case studies into the breadth of qualitative

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literature to be examined. Case studies explore social behavior and experiences in an in-depth manner and therefore offer an opportunity to further understand in-depth experiences of grief. To exclude qualitative case studies is to assume that we cannot generalize from a single case, nor can we easily summarize their findings, which are assumptions that are not supported in research (Flyvbjerg, 2006). Therefore, the purpose of this paper is to review and synthesize a full range of qualitative studies that explored the experience of the death of a pet, grief reaction, and the impact of bereavement on the pet owners.

Methods

Thomas and Harden's (2008) thematic synthesis methodology guided this qualitative systematic review in conjunction with the Enhancing transparency in reporting the synthesis of qualitative research statement (Tong et al., 2012).

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

The included studies met the following criteria: primary qualitative research published in peer-reviewed journals; published in the English language with no parameters imposed on the date of publication; and qualitative studies primarily discussing the bereavement or grief at the death of a pet by pet owners or caretakers. Studies reporting the loss of a pet due to reasons other than death such as relinquishment, disappearance, or separation were excluded. Studies with veterinarians and service providers (e.g., mortuary) were also excluded. In addition, editorials, dissertations, conference proceedings, reviews, and abstracts were excluded.

Search strategy

An extensive literature search was conducted up until 7th August 2020 without any limits on the date of publication (RK, MC) using the electronic databases Scopus, Cumulative Index of Nursing and Allied Health Literature (CINAHL), PubMed, and PsycINFO. The Boolean connectors AND/OR and NOT were applied to combine the following Medical Subject Headings (MeSH) and keywords: bereavement, grief, loss, attitude to death, euthanasia, domestic animals, cats, dogs, bonding, pets, companion animal, and qualitative research. The search strategy was adapted to accommodate for the differences in index terms and syntax across the databases.

The screening of all titles and abstracts of the identified papers through the search strategy was performed independently by RK, MC, and DKT in accordance with the inclusion and exclusion criteria.

Search outcome

A total of 498 papers were identified through the literature search. After the removal of 82 duplicates, 416 titles and abstracts were systematically screened with 391 not meeting the inclusion criteria. Twenty-five full-text articles were retrieved for eligibility and seven were excluded accordingly. A review of the reference list of included studies identified one additional article that met the inclusion criteria. Thus, a total of 19 qualitative primary papers (from 17 studies) were included in this systematic review. See Figure 1 for the PRISMA flow diagram.

Quality appraisal

Quality appraisal of the included studies that met the inclusion criteria was performed (by RK, MC, DKT) using the Critical Appraisal Skills Programme for Qualitative Studies Checklist (Critical Appraisal Skills Programme, 2018). No articles were excluded based on quality assessment alone (Supplementary Table 1).

Data extraction and synthesis

SW with other team members (MC, DKT, RK) conducted the data extraction and synthesis of the included studies using Thomas and Harden's (2008) thematic synthesis. Across the studies, identified themes were grouped into similar concepts, and data are presented in a narrative synthesis.

Results

The results were drawn from 19 separate papers, representing 17 studies (Bussolari et al., 2019 and Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017 were from the same study, as were Packman, Kelley, et al., 2017 and Packman et al., 2011). These included studies involved a total of 2,331 participants. Participants of studies included those who knowingly and deliberately volunteered to participate in interviews or questionnaires, those who provided comments online, those who contacted a support hotline where notes of their conversation were kept, and a narrative reflection on poetry. A total of 10 articles derived data from interviews (Adams et al., 1999; Bunkers, 2010; Kwong &

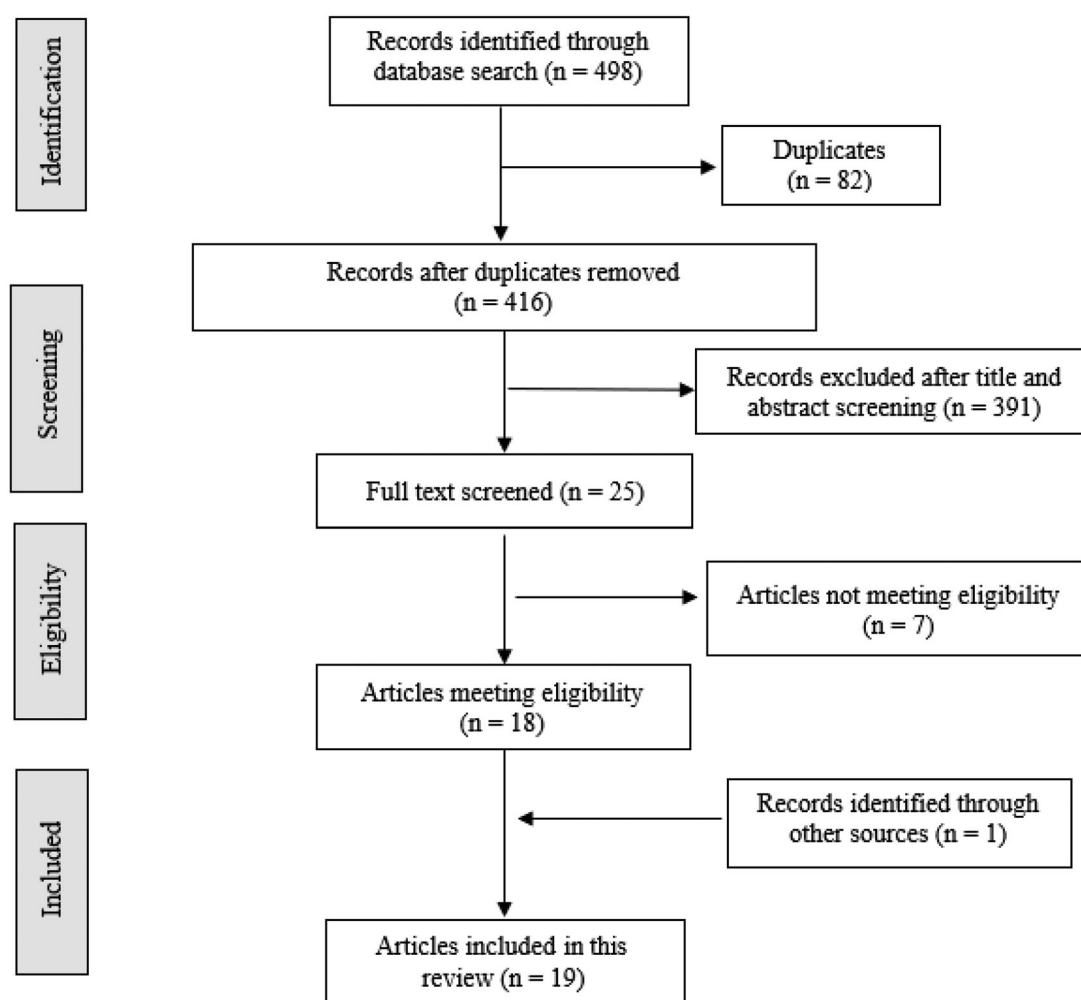


Figure 1. PRISMA Flow diagram of selected studies (19 papers from 17 studies).

Bartholomew, 2011; Packman et al., 2011; Packman, Kelley, et al., 2017; Redmalm, 2015; Reisbig et al., 2017; Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018; Tzivian et al., 2014; Wong et al., 2017), five from questionnaires (Bussolari et al., 2019; Bussolari et al., 2018; Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017; Packman et al., 2014), one was a narrative reflection on poetry (Furman, 2005), and three were content analyses—one of the online comments on a media article (Laing & Maylea, 2018), one of the notes made by hotline volunteers (Rémillard et al., 2017), and one using notes made by hotline volunteers and some field observation (Turner, 1997).

Characteristics of the included studies

Table 1 presents a summary of included studies. The papers included in this review came from seven countries: three from Canada (Adams et al., 1999; Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011; Rémillard et al., 2017); 10 from the USA (Bunkers, 2010; Bussolari et al., 2018, 2019;

Furman, 2005; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017; Packman et al., 2014; Packman et al., 2011; Packman, Kelley, et al., 2017; Reisbig et al., 2017; Turner, 1997); one from Sweden (Redmalm, 2015); one from Hong Kong (Wong et al., 2017); one from Israel (Tzivian et al., 2014); one from Romania (Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018); and two from Australia (Laing & Maylea, 2018; Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019). As one involved online comments, it cannot be known if all participants were from the country of the study (Australia) (Laing & Maylea, 2018).

Of all study participants, the vast majority were female ($n = 1728$), with 310 males and 293 with gender not stated. The ages of the participants varied with the youngest being 18 years and the eldest 91 years. The relationship between that of participant and animal was largely expressed as that of owner and pet, with some participants being from the general population (Laing & Maylea, 2018), one being specifically the relationship between the owner and assistance dogs (Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011), and one is

Table 1. Summary of included studies ($n = 17$).

Reference Country	Aims	Sample and study population	Data collection and analysis	Findings
Adams et al. (1999) Canada	To develop a theory to describe owner response to the death of a pet.	44 (30 females) participants who had experienced death of their pet recruited from veterinary clinics Mean age of 48 (21–75) years	Grounded theory Nondirective interviews	Reactions of bereavement and grief were influenced by social and psychological factors. Social factors included social values and norms of bereavement and grief, and the cultural milieu of pet death (including social network and veterinary medicine), and psychological factors included individual's beliefs, stage of life, significant events, and animal qualities. Loss of a pet encompassed 3 themes: • Penetrating anguish • Contemplating absent-yet present intimacies • Prevailing amid misfortune Relating to others, which includes attachment relationship, unconditional love, and reciprocity. Participants acknowledged feelings of self-reliance and strength especially through the process of euthanasia. Participants referred to a spiritual dimension. Participants felt closer to family members and more compassion for others after the loss of a pet. Post-traumatic growth occurred for those experiencing a loss of a pet.
Bunkers (2010) USA	To enhance understanding of the lived experience of feeling sad.	7 (3 females) older adults who had lost their pet Age range: 62–85 years	Phenomenological hermeneutic study Interviews	4 themes: • Grief without guilt • Euthanasia as appropriate decision, accompanied by guilt and/or ambivalence • Sole expression of guilt • Veterinarian collaboration with decision Poetry used in conjunction with narrative reflections to convey the meaning of the loss of a pet.
Bussolari et al. (2019), Packman, Bussolari, et al. (2017) USA	To qualitatively investigate the construct of posttraumatic growth in a sample of participants who have lost their companion animal.	743 (636 females) bereaved pet owners recruited from pet loss support groups Mean age across the study countries ranged from 35 (SD = 8, Hong Kong) to 42 (SD = 12, USA) years	Online or mailed questionnaire Qualitative Analytic Procedure (open ended questions)	4 themes: • Grief without guilt • Euthanasia as appropriate decision, accompanied by guilt and/or ambivalence • Sole expression of guilt • Veterinarian collaboration with decision Poetry used in conjunction with narrative reflections to convey the meaning of the loss of a pet.
Bussolari et al. (2018) USA	To explore and assess bereaved companion animal owners' responses to a question about the decision to euthanize their animal.	762 (665 females) bereaved pet owners recruited via requests posted online and personal solicitations to pet loss support groups Mean age of 46.5 (range 18–76; SD = 12.5) years	Online or mailed questionnaire Content analysis (qualitative data)	4 themes: • Grief without guilt • Euthanasia as appropriate decision, accompanied by guilt and/or ambivalence • Sole expression of guilt • Veterinarian collaboration with decision Poetry used in conjunction with narrative reflections to convey the meaning of the loss of a pet.
Furman (2005) USA	To explore the meaning of the death of a companion animal through autoethnographic poetry in conjunction with narrative reflections.	Auto-ethnographic study of an adult who had experienced the loss of a pet (dog) Single self-study Researcher as participant	Narrative reflections of the poems that the owner wrote concerning illness and the imminent death of a pet	4 themes: • Grief without guilt • Euthanasia as appropriate decision, accompanied by guilt and/or ambivalence • Sole expression of guilt • Veterinarian collaboration with decision Poetry used in conjunction with narrative reflections to convey the meaning of the loss of a pet.
Kwong and Bartholomew (2011) Canada	To explore individuals' relationships with an assistance dog from an attachment-theory perspective.	25 (16 females) participants who had experienced the loss of at least one assistance dog recruited from dog-training organizations Mean age of 49.0 (range 27–78; SD = 12.7) years	Semi-structured interviews Thematic analysis	Participants experienced intense grief, sadness, distress which persisted for years as a result of the loss of a caregiving relationship.
Laing and Maylea (2018) Australia	To investigate the role that social workers could perform to support bereaved companion animal guardians.	218 online responses/comments to an article on the topic of losing a companion animal	Qualitative thematic analysis	4 themes: • Strength of the bond • Disenfranchised grief • Anticipatory grief in the context of euthanasia • Need for professional support Those who lost pets expressed varying levels of grief.
Lavorgna and Hutton (2019) Australia	To build on the limited existing literature comparing the grief experience of human and companion animal loss within the one study.	50 (41 females) participants who had experienced the death of a human (n = 35) or the death of a companion animal (n = 15) Mean age of 40.5 (range 22–66; SD = 13.5) years	Qualitative component of online questionnaire Text analysis	4 themes: • Strength of the bond • Disenfranchised grief • Anticipatory grief in the context of euthanasia • Need for professional support Those who lost pets expressed varying levels of grief.

(Continued)

Table 1. Continued.

Reference Country	Aims	Sample and study population	Data collection and analysis	Findings
Packman et al. (2014) USA	To investigate grief reactions of bereaved individuals following the death of a pet.	235 (203 females) bereaved pet owners recruited via requests posted online and direct personal solicitations to pet loss support groups Mean age, USA 43.7 (SD = 12.5) and French-Canadian 42.5 (SD = 11.4) years	Online or mailed questionnaire Content analysis	Intensity of bereavement and loss extended to feeling clinically depressed and suicidal. 4 themes: • Lack of validation and support • Intensity of loss • Nature of the human pet relationship • Continuing bonds
Packman et al. (2011) Packman, Kelley, et al. (2017) USA	To investigate the grief reaction and continuing impact of the death of a pet; and to examine the relationship among projective drawings and mental health symptomatology.	33 (27 females) pet owners who lost a pet through death within 12 months from the date of data collection Recruited from veterinary clinics, family centers, practicum and internship sites, and at a pet loss support group Mean age of 45.6 (range 25–79) years	Semi-structured clinical interview Visualizing the deceased pet through projective drawings	Pet owners maintained meaningful relationship with their departed pet by means of fond memories, rituals and dreams. Feelings of regret that they had not spent enough time with their pets or provided appropriate care to extend the pet's life. Fond memories of special times, that is, birthdays, family events, holidays. Participants with severe grief and/or somatization experienced poorer psychosocial adjustment.
Redmalm (2015) Sweden	To explore how pet owners grieve their pets and view their pets' transience.	18 (11 females) pet owners recruited from researcher's personal network and pet owners' organizations Half of the sample were younger than 40 years (range 20–70 years)	Semi-structured interviews	Butler's conceptualization of grief framed pet owner's response to a loss of a pet. • Irreplaceability • Unpredictability • Embodied loss • When is non-human life ungrievable?
Reisbig et al. (2017) USA	To describe human–animal relationships and the subsequent loss and coping experienced by owners of beloved companion animals.	12 (7 females) participants who lost their pet Mean age of 61.8 (range 44–91) years	Semi-structured interviews Phenomenology	3 themes: • Quality of the relationship with the animal • Experience of loss • Ways of coping
Rémillard et al. (2017) Canada	To explore the grief experience among callers to a Pet Loss Support Hotline (PLSH).	Summary notes (n = 75) of the conversations between callers and PLSH volunteers	Content analysis	Major content categories emerging from the analysis include personal pet narrative; perceived support sources; grief experiences; relationship with pet; memorialization; grief coping strategies; grief triggers; decision to euthanize; and veterinary interaction.
Rujoiu and Rujoiu (2018) Romania	The story of a Romanian military working dog hero named Max and how his situation changes the status of his peers.	Interview with the handler of a deceased military dog	Semi-structured interview	The dog will be forever close to his handler's heart. The handler's connection with the German Shepherd breed remains special, and he remembers all the good memories with the dog when he sees the same breed. The dog was buried with military honors.
Turner (1997) USA	To explore the workings of a Pet Loss Support Hotline (PLSH) to discover the types of situations presented by callers and also to gain insight into how the hotline volunteers dealt with these presenting situations.	Participant observation at three PLSH Rounds, and summary notes (n = 47) of the conversations between callers and PLSH volunteers 41/47 callers were females	Participant observation and content analysis	Pet owners who called the hotline were experiencing some type of distress over the loss of the pet. The contact with the hotline and the requests for information regarding support groups indicates that these persons were seeking other sources for emotional support. The hotline training did not adequately prepare the volunteers for situations such as veterinary care, or counseling on how to support those who have lost a pet.

(Continued)

Table 1. Continued.

Reference Country	Aims	Sample and study population	Data collection and analysis	Findings
Tzivian et al. (2014) Israel	To explore the common reactions of dogs' owners to the death of the companion dog, including their emotional status before and after euthanasia.	29 (24 females) owners in the 2-week period after the death of their dogs recruited from veterinary clinics Median age of 49 (range 18–64) years	Semi-structured interviews Qualitative exploratory study, content analysis	5 main phases in the initial parting process: • Decision to euthanize • Anticipating death and preparation • Burial • Mourning • Replacement/substitution The intensity of grief seemed to be affected by factors like the strength of the human–animal bond, lack of empathy from closed ones, being married without children, the decision to euthanize. Although the bereavement was distressful for many of our participants, many of them gradually achieved personal growth from their loss experience.
Wong et al. (2017) Hong Kong	To explore the impact of animal loss on humans, the challenges it might pose for animal lovers, and the resources some severely bereaved need for grief coping.	31 (24 females) participants who lost their pet within 3 years Participants were approached through animal welfare agencies, veterinary clinics, funeral parlors for animals	In-depth interviews Constant comparison analysis	

SD: standard deviation.

a single case report about a military dog handler (Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018). One study compared the loss of either a loved one (human) or a pet (Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019).

The kinds of animals kept as pets were largely dogs, cats, or undefined. One study, however, mentioned participants having horses, rats, snakes, lizards, birds, and fish (Redmalm, 2015), another referred to exotic pets and ferrets (Turner, 1997) while another also mentioned rabbits (Wong et al., 2017). With regards to the choice to euthanize (which featured heavily in discussions by participants), three studies specifically mentioned rates of euthanasia which ranged from 64 to 69% (Adams et al., 1999; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017; Packman et al., 2014).

Synthesis of the identified themes

Across the 19 articles and 17 studies, findings were presented across a disparate range of foci and study aims. When examined systematically, five core themes were consistently found. The themes centered on the experience of the owner/handler/participant: their relationship; their grief; their guilt; their supports; and their future. All findings presented by the studies fell within these categories.

Their relationship

All studies touched on the relationship between the owner and their pet/companion animal/assistance animal/working animal, presenting this relationship as being one of a significant bond. This bond was created through numerous elements, such as being present during major life events like divorce or miscarriage (Adams et al., 1999), unconditional love and acceptance (Furman, 2005; Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011), the meeting of rational needs such as companionship or reducing stress (Reisbig et al., 2017), or being a dependable teammate during times of conflict (Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018). This bond made the animal appear “irreplaceable” to some owners (Redmalm, 2015) and occasionally created a sense of interdependence where both humans and animals influenced one another (Reisbig et al., 2017).

For some participants, the description of their relationship extended beyond that of being a significant bond, and instead they described their pet as being more akin to their child or a direct member of their family (Laing & Maylea, 2018; Reisbig et al., 2017; Rémillard et al., 2017; Turner, 1997), particularly when the owner was childless or had no children left

at home. This often meant that the loss of an animal was comparable to the loss of a human for that owner (Wong et al., 2017) and that owners felt a sense of grief similar to the notion that a parent should never have to bury a child (Reisbig et al., 2017).

For others, the relationship was described in terms of caregiving. Some owners described themselves as caregivers who derived pleasure from the physical act of caring for their pets, such as grooming and bathing, as well as developing a sense of responsibility because of their caregiving role (Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011; Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018). One study also noted that providing care helped to develop trust, which could be important in the context of the relationship (Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018). Others acknowledged that their pet provided caregiving to them. This was particularly applicable for assistance dogs, where the increased mobility and functionality that came with their assistance produced an emotional benefit that further increased the significance of the bond (Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011). Pets were also considered as caregivers when they provided emotional support during times of need, giving their owners perseverance and resilience (Reisbig et al., 2017; Tzivian et al., 2014).

Despite the closeness of the bond being universally discussed, and despite the benefits derived from this relationship, some participants identified that others may not understand this closeness, and consequently they employed jokes about their own relationship with their pets as a way to acknowledge this disapproval (Redmalm, 2015).

Their grief

Due to the nature of the study aims, almost all participants discussed a component of grief relating to the death of their pet or companion animal. Grief was described in many ways, such as “feeling lost”, “emptiness”, and “having love” for the deceased animal (Bunkers, 2010). It was a grief that had no time limit and could be socially isolating (Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019), and could be equally as difficult to face as the death of a significant human (Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011). The grief experienced could involve physical symptoms of feeling sick, loss of appetite (Rémillard et al., 2017), and nightmares, as well as time off work (Tzivian et al., 2014). However, the severity of this grief was very much contextual. One study highlighted that a range of factors mitigated or exacerbated grief, such as whether the person had other demands such as young children, or

whether they had previously experienced the death of a pet (Adams et al., 1999; Reisbig et al., 2017). Also, the type of animal could determine the severity of grief, with some participants indicating that they did not grieve their snakes, fish, or birds in the same way they would have a dog or cat, while others did not grieve cats but did pigs and birds (Redmalm, 2015). The naturally short lifespan of many pets also defined the extent of grief, with the pre-existing knowledge of their eventual death structuring the relationship and ensuring the time spent together was valued (Redmalm, 2015).

The responses by owners to their grief were indicative of their coping strategies and varied from deliberate and successful to avoidant and counterproductive. One study reported psychosocial adjustment and those with greater severity of grief showed poorer psychosocial adjustment (Packman, Kelley, et al., 2017).

One participant perceived the passing of time as the main coping mechanism, with grief diminishing from “overwhelming” to a sense of missing their pet (Furman, 2005). Others indicated that although their grief was painful, they did not wish to avoid it, but rather allow healing through sadness, indicating they perceived this grief as an important part of the relationship (Redmalm, 2015; Reisbig et al., 2017). Another identified coping mechanism was to reframe the pet as “ungrievable” by considering it as replaceable (Redmalm, 2015) while others used avoidance through social isolation and changing the reality of the death experience (Reisbig et al., 2017).

An important part of the grief process for many was the instigation of rituals. Normally the loss of a pet does not require the formal burial arrangements and ceremonies that are expected following the death of a human (Adams et al., 1999). This can lead to a sense that pet death is not significant and does not need to be commemorated in the same way as humans. Indeed, one study found that over half of its participants were never informed about burial options for their pets, leading to feelings of anger about feeling uninformed (Adams et al., 1999). However, many participants detailed rituals or spiritual connections to their pets that allowed them to commemorate that relationship. This included feelings of “sensing their pet’s presence” (Packman et al., 2011; Reisbig et al., 2017), keeping special items that belonged to the pet, setting up home altars, creating scrapbooks, poetry, donations (Packman et al., 2011), or simply cherishing fond memories (Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019). Several referred to holding memorials for the pet (Packman et al., 2011; Rémillard et al., 2017; Tzivian et al., 2014).

which led to these participants feeling calmer and comforted. These rituals and spiritual connections can be considered as a form of a continuing bond, whereby the bereaved adapt by developing new memories, feelings, and actions that help maintain a sense of connection to the deceased (Klass et al., 2014).

A commonly occurring component of grief was disenfranchised grief that was considered unique to pet bereavement. The absence of a proper grieving protocol for pets was indicative of a lack of societal value toward pet death. This led participants to struggle with their feelings of overwhelming grief in the face of societal disapproval, and even minimize or hide their true grief to fit with societal norms (Adams et al., 1999; Laing & Maylea, 2018; Lavorgna & Hutton, 2019; Turner, 1997; Wong et al., 2017).

Their guilt

A common element unique to pet bereavement that featured in nine of 19 articles was the issue of euthanasia. The decision to end the life and suffering of a pet is one that is commonly supported and deemed as culturally acceptable, unlike similar decisions to end human suffering. Yet the decision to euthanize a pet was described as a complex one, exacerbated by the closeness of the human-pet bond. A common resultant theme was guilt and difficulty with making the final decision (Furman, 2005; Reisbig et al., 2017; Rémillard et al., 2017; Turner, 1997; Tzivian et al., 2014; Wong et al., 2017). While the decision to euthanize could be considered a compassionate choice to make, others would reevaluate their decisions afterward and question whether they made the correct decision (Reisbig et al., 2017; Wong et al., 2017). Validation or encouragement of the decision by a vet or counselor was considered an important component in minimizing guilt and reaffirming their decision (Reisbig et al., 2017; Turner, 1997; Tzivian et al., 2014). Two studies did not have findings of guilt. In one, three-quarters of participants viewed euthanasia as appropriate and subsequently felt sadness but not guilt over their decision (Bussolari et al., 2018). In the other, some participants viewed euthanasia as fair and part of the responsibility of being an owner (Redmalm, 2015). Euthanasia was further compounded by “anticipatory grief”, which was experienced in the days, months and even years leading up to euthanasia once the owner felt that this outcome was inevitable (Laing & Maylea, 2018; Tzivian et al., 2014). This allowed some to mentally prepare and engage in almost ritualistic acts to prepare for the

event, such as feeding or bathing, allowing them treats, or providing comfort and words of love.

Their supports

As identified above with the decision to euthanize, support was identified as integral to handling the bereavement process for pet owners in nine articles. In one study, approximately half of pet owners considered support to be present and available which could take the form of support groups, friends and family, veterinarians, or others (Rémillard et al., 2017). Discussing their feelings of bereavement was viewed as a means to reduce psychological pressure (Adams et al., 1999). While an inability to discuss their feelings caused people to question their own mental stability (Adams et al., 1999), good support networks allowed greater posttraumatic growth (Reisbig et al., 2017; Wong et al., 2017).

Family and friends were a key source of support (Reisbig et al., 2017; Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018; Tzivian et al., 2014). This support assisted coping by allowing the owner to maintain conversations about the deceased, acknowledge their grief as real, and keeping participants busy (Reisbig et al., 2017). Social workers or hotline counselors were also identified as having a support role (Laing & Maylea, 2018; Turner, 1997; Wong et al., 2017). Results varied as to how confident some counselors felt in answering questions they received, which indicated that some might benefit from further training or focus in order to fully meet people's support requirements (Turner, 1997).

The most discussed source of support (or lack thereof) was veterinarians (Adams et al., 1999; Bussolari et al., 2018; Laing & Maylea, 2018; Reisbig et al., 2017; Rémillard et al., 2017; Tzivian et al., 2014). When participants identified positive interactions and high levels of support from their veterinarians, they found they were better able to grieve, had a strong sense of trust and collaboration, had reduced trauma, and felt reassured. Not all studies, however, noted positive views of veterinarians. Rémillard et al. (2017) found that of all callers who contacted a support hotline and mentioned veterinarians, two-thirds had negative interactions, citing concerns related to perceived judgment, treatments, pain management, cost, lack of communication, and lack of compassion.

Their future

The final theme focused on how participants perceived their futures post-bereavement, including

positive and negative experiences, learned through bereavement and the possibility of future pets.

Positive lessons learned from the experience of pet bereavement included: perseverance and resilience (Bunkers, 2010; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017); feeling closer to family and others (Bussolari et al., 2019; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017; Wong et al., 2017); development of self-reliance, courage and personal strength (Bussolari et al., 2019; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017; Packman et al., 2011; Wong et al., 2017); a stronger appreciation of life (Bussolari et al., 2019; Furman, 2005; Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017); and the cherishing of memories (Rujoiu & Rujoiu, 2018).

Negative lessons derived from the experience of pet bereavement were not extensively discussed but did appear in three studies in small numbers. In one study, a small number had come to question their faith (Packman, Bussolari, et al., 2017). In another, one-third of participants (23/75) found the experience left them with triggers that would renew feelings of grief for them (Rémillard et al., 2017). In a further study, some participants (an unspecified small number) became stuck in the experience of grief, resulting in social detachment, depression, anxiety, and poor insight into their experience (Wong et al., 2017).

The final aspect of the conversation for participants was whether they saw a place for new pets in their future. Here the findings varied significantly. For one group of participants, replacing the deceased pet was a necessity due to their role as service dogs, but this created guilt for owners who replaced the animal quickly (Kwong & Bartholomew, 2011). In one study, participants expressed a view that they could not live without a pet and therefore the first pet could not be considered as irreplaceable (Redmalm, 2015) whilst another had 44% of participants stating they wished for another pet to “fill the void” (Rémillard et al., 2017). However, in another study over half of those who had no second pet remaining were adamant they would never get another pet (Tzivian et al., 2014). The presence of a second pet was important in mitigating bereavement, with those having a second pet believing this helped with acceptance of their loss.

Discussion

The synthesis of the findings of studies on pet bereavement drew some consistent conclusions on the strength of the human–animal bond and the often parent-to-child-like relationship that can develop. This bond is one that can begin in childhood and can shape that person as a caretaker in their adult years

(Wanser et al., 2019). The studies reviewed showed that from the strength of the human–animal relationship came the expected consequences of bereavement—guilt, sadness, rituals, and ceremonies to help frame grief—and the extent of grief was either minimized or exacerbated by good or poor support networks. Differences related to pet grief were reinforced, namely the experience of multiple instances of loss and grief over their lifetimes, anticipatory grief due to shorter life spans of pets, the necessity to often make life and death decisions relating to euthanasia, and disenfranchised grief when pet bereavement was considered inappropriate by broader social norms.

The juxtaposition between the way pet owners wanted to feel about their bereavement and the way this bereavement was seen by society as lesser was a particularly strong focus. Many owners exhibited emotions and rituals like that of grief for humans yet were consistent in their experiences that their grief was not considered equal to grief for a human, whether this was a perception held by them or one expressed to them by others. Although some research has shown grief severity to be higher with the loss of a human, the effect sizes were small and the most important predictor of grief severity remained the closeness of the person to the human or pet that has passed away (Eckerd et al., 2016).

By creating a distinction and difference between grief for a human and grief for a pet in society, the experience of grief was not lessened for those pet owners but instead created more complex grief. Their disenfranchised grief through social constraints has been shown to impact the bereaved in tangible ways, with poorer outcomes experienced in rates of anxiety, depression, somatization, and functional impairment (Bussolari et al., 2021). These grief responses are equally as complex when the owner is involved in the process of euthanasia. Consistent with the studies included in this review, strong pet attachment has been found to be strongly linked to experiences of sorrow and anger among owners whose pets are euthanized (Barnard-Nguyen et al., 2016).

Due to the integral link between euthanasia and veterinary practice, there remains a clear role for veterinarians in minimizing negative experiences and mitigating grief severity for pet owners involved in decisions on euthanasia. Some research has reflected upon such strategies in veterinary practice that redirects or reinterprets negative emotions into something more constructive (Morris, 2012), such as an expression of love for their pet (e.g., painting), or a focus on how this action will end the suffering of their pet.

Equally, the evidence of poor psychosocial and mental health outcomes for many bereaved pet owners provides scope for health and social support professionals, be they nurses, counselors, or general practitioners, to identify this trauma and anticipate the impacts this can have. By looking beyond the disenfranchisement of grief and accepting the validity and severity of this form of bereavement, the health sector can respond to bereaved pet owners in the same way they would for any other form of bereavement. A bereavement is a form of trauma and as such there are many models that can be engaged to respond to people bereaved by companion animal loss in a way that acknowledges this loss and its impact on their mental and psychosocial wellbeing. Interventions such as empathically attuned and person-centered engagement, avoidance of re-traumatization through awareness, and the use of trauma-informed staff are simple and tangible ways that health care staff have responded to pre-existing trauma in patients in the general health care setting (Cleary et al., 2018). Future directions in research that builds upon this understanding of companion animal loss and disenfranchised grief could focus existing interventions specifically on the animal health care sector and those who seek support services post-bereavement. Such a response would acknowledge the closeness of the human–animal bond and the very real experience of bereavement felt when this relationship is brought to an end.

Limitations

Our qualitative review provides the highest level of research synthesis, allowing for a more holistic view of the issue of pet bereavement. Also, by leaving the review unlimited by time, the greatest number of studies could be included. However, by including only qualitative studies, any quantitative or mixed methods analyses were not able to be incorporated and compared to determine if such methods enhanced or provided a counterpoint to the qualitative findings. The inclusion of mainly pets or companion animals in the study also precluded analysis and comparison of bereavement experienced toward assistance dogs or working dogs. Further, by limiting the analysis to owners and caretakers who had been bereaved the study was unable to consider the impact of grief on others who may be affected, such as veterinarians, nor could it consider whether the experience of non-death related loss, such as relinquishment, resulted in the same or similar thoughts and feelings.

The wide-ranging methodology for the included studies also proved to be perhaps a challenge rather

than a limitation. Deriving themes from data such as poetry and paintings were less straightforward when data was coded for thematic analysis as it required more deliberate thought and discussion as to the way in which this data could be interpreted. Interpretation naturally opens data up to interpretation bias and as such the themes derived from the data are affected by this.

Conclusion

Grief is a complex emotion and bereavement likewise a complex process. Individuals navigate the experience in vastly different ways, mitigated and amplified by many factors both intrinsic and extrinsic. Extrinsically, societal norms and values have shaped a sense of what is right and acceptable in periods of bereavement and many have reflected the lack of support that follows when the loss is a pet. However, the experience of grief feels equally as tangible to many people who experience this as it does when the loss is a human loved one. Consequently, a juxtaposition occurs between the feelings they want to feel and the feelings they believe they ought to feel. This, coupled with the pet-specific factors of anticipatory grief and guilt from euthanasia, creates a unique experience for those affected by pet bereavement. This experience has been studied across many countries and using many forms of data collection and analysis, with some consistent themes emerging from these. By systematically examining these similarities and indeed differences through this review more understanding can be drawn which, in turn, will shape and target services that might be offered to those affected by pet bereavement. When support services can anticipate and identify this form of grief and its potential severity they can respond in a more effective manner and provide what is needed to positively assist people to move through their bereavement.

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